Phone Interview Preparation Guidebook

Congratulations on your phone interview request with AWS. This Prep Guide is designed to support your phone interview preparation. Your phone interview will cover both technical and functional areas.

Logistics to be prepared with before the interview

- Ensure you have a good laptop with proper internet connectivity and video capabilities.
- Please refer to Amazon Chime Guide and download Chime in advance.
- Please be prepared for an introduction and any questions you may have about the role.

The overview of the 1 hour is as follows:

- 1 Coding question.
- 1 Leadership principle-based question.

To be prepared for a Coding Assessment:

During your technical phone interview, we will ask you to solve one coding problem in the language of your choice. This will be a live coding exercise with no IDE or compiler available. The interviewer will be looking for you to write production like code.

Best Practices to Keep in mind during Coding Assessment:

- **Ask Clarifying questions** to uncover new information from the problem statement. Explain what you are trying to achieve as you are coding.
- **Write simple code** where possible with few syntax errors.
- **Use variable names** that describe their function and which follow a consistent theme throughout your code.
- **Write in a modular fashion**, going from higher-level functions and breaking them down into smaller.
- **After coding**, check your code and add test cases. Interviewers expect you to scan the code for errors and adding test cases to improve on your code.
- **Brainstorm edge cases** with the interviewer and add additional test cases. Note that the given test cases are usually simple by design. Brainstorm on possible edge cases such as large sized inputs, empty sets, single item sets, negative numbers. (Refer to Algorithms Cheat Sheets for common corner cases).
- **Reiterate the time and space complexity** of your code.
- **Explain trade-offs** and how the code / approach can be improved if given more time.

Optional resources to refer for your Interview prep:

- Amazon's online coding Assessment
- https://www.topcoder.com/
- https://www.interviewcake.com/
- Geeksforgeeks.org
- https://projecteuler.net/

Books to refer:

- Cracking the Coding Interview
- Grokking Algorithm
- Elements of Programming Interviews

System Design:

Best Practices to Keep in mind during System design

- **In addition to the coding prep**, it's good to be prepared to speak on the system you have designed, why you chose to make certain decisions or use specific technologies and how you can make it more scalable.
- **Another way to be prepared** is to take your favorite app and try to reverse-engineer it. For example, Twitter. Think of how you would create a design keeping in mind the UI, backend, data flow, security features keeping in mind the needs of the customer.
- **Ask clarifying questions** before you start to explain your design Be prepared to talk about the technologies such as the database, API, etc. Compare and contrast possible approaches. Talk it through!

> - **You can consider to review this link or similar websites for System Design Prep**
> - **Amazon recommended video on System Design**

Behavioral questions – Leadership principle questions. "Tell me about a time when..."

To help prepare further for your Interview check out the following, Brush up on the Leadership Principles that make us who we are at AWS.

Best Practices to Keep in mind while answering LP questions:

1. **Add as much data points** as possible to support your stories with valid data/metrics.
2. **Use STAR method** and keep your stories short and to the point.
3. **Use I statement** and keep your stories focused on your individual contributions.
4. **Do not be Vague** or high level with your answers.

> **Resources to refer for Leadership Principles prep:**
> - Amazon recommended video on Leadership Principles
> - Sample behavioral question answered in STAR format

Some of the questions may look similar to this:

- Tell me about a time you had to decide without as much data as you would have liked, but you allowed your intuition to shape the direction you chose.
- Tell me about a time you refused to compromise your standards around code quality.
- Give me an example of a time when you were able to deliver an important project under a tight deadline.
- Tell me about a project that didn't go as planned and how you may improve them the next time?
- Think about times you've had to make business critical decisions independently.

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- Explore Interviewing at Amazon for FAQs, prep guides and more.

If you would like to request an accommodation for the interview, please let your recruiter know and they can connect you to our accommodation team. You may also reach them directly by visiting https://www.amazon.jobs/en/disability/us (if in the US).

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